

Lesson Plan — French Revolution

History | Grade 9-10 | Intermediate | French Revolution

Overview

Subject	History
Grade band	9-10
Topic	French Revolution
Chapter	French Revolution
Source document	French Revolution
Periods	6 x 40 min

Learning Objectives

- [remember] Recall the conventional start and end events and dates of the French Revolution as stated in the text.
- [understand] Explain how social, economic, financial and political factors combined to produce a crisis that led to the Revolution, using evidence from the chapter.
- [analyze] Analyze the sequence of events from the calling of the Estates-General in May 1789 through the Tennis Court Oath to the National Constituent Assembly and identify at least three concrete actions the Third Estate took during that process.
- [understand] Explain why the Storming of the Bastille became a potent symbol of the Ancien Régime despite the fortress holding few prisoners, citing the chapter's description.
- [understand] Describe the immediate legal changes enacted by the August Decrees concerning feudal dues and church tithes and one practical difficulty the text reports in implementing them.
- [analyze] Explain how confiscation of church property and the issue of assignats related to the fiscal situation and inflation as described in the chapter.
- [understand] Summarise the main measures and human costs of the Reign of Terror between September 1793 and July 1794 using specific figures provided in the text.
- [evaluate] Compare two interpretations from the chapter about the role of Enlightenment ideology versus pragmatic responses in driving revolutionary actions and give one piece of evidence the chapter uses for each view.
- [understand] Describe how wartime mobilization changed French military scale and political dynamics between 1792 and 1795, citing the chapter's figures.
- [analyze] Explain the chapter's account of how metropolitan debates over rights affected the colonies, especially Saint-Domingue, and what policy responses from 1791 to 1793 followed.

Period-by-Period Plan

Period 1: Origins: Causes, Estates-General, Bastille

Concepts	Causes of the Revolution (multiple factors), Estates General of 1789 and Third Estate actions, Tennis Court Oath, Storming of the Bastille (14 July 1789)
Objectives	Explain how social, economic, financial and political factors combined to produce a crisis that led to the Revolution, using evidence from the chapter.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge (5 min), Introduce new material (10 min), Role play & source comparison (12 min), Debate (8 min), Check and consolidate (5 min)
Why this order	As the opening period, this lesson establishes how social, economic, financial and political crises and royal indecision produced a breaking point and explains the Estates-General, the Third Estate's actions, the Tennis Court Oath, and the Storming of the Bastille; mastering these events prepares students to evaluate the August Decrees, the Declaration of the Rights of Man, and later crises such as the flight to Varennes.

Period 2: From August Decrees to Constitutional Monarchy

Concepts	August Decrees and abolition of feudalism, Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen, Constitutional monarchy phase (July 1789 e2 2 September 1792), Louis XVI's flight to Varennes (June 1791)
Objectives	Analyze the sequence of events from the calling of the Estates-General in May 1789 through the Tennis Court Oath to the National Constituent Assembly and identify at least three concrete actions the Third Estate took during that process.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge (5 min), Introduce new material (10 min), Group analysis and debate (12 min), Role play and peer critique (7 min), Check for understanding and consolidate (6 min)
Why this order	Builds on the Estates-General, Tennis Court Oath and Bastille events to show how the Assembly translated revolutionary pressure into legal change (August Decrees, Declaration) and how Louis XVI's flight led to the constitutional monarchy's collapse; prepares students to analyze the Republic's proclamation and the Reign of Terror as consequences of these breakdowns.

Period 3: Republic Proclaimed and the Reign of Terror

Concepts	Proclamation of the French First Republic (1792), Reign of Terror (Sept 1793 e2 2 July 1794), Assignats (paper currency backed by confiscated church property), Repression during the Terror
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Objectives

Summarise the main measures and human costs of the Reign of Terror between September 1793 and July 1794 using specific figures provided in the text.

Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge (5 min), Introduce key facts (10 min), Group discussion (competing interpretations) (12 min), Role-play courtroom (7 min), Check for understanding (3 min), Consolidate (3 min)
Why this order	Builds on the fall of the monarchy, the August Decrees and the constitutional monarchy phase by explaining how the Convention declared the First Republic and moved to emergency governance. This period prepares students to evaluate the Directory's political problems and the Revolution's lasting effects in the following lesson.

Period 4: Directory, Ideology Debate, and Wars

Concepts	French Directory (1795–1799) — structure and problems, Contested role of ideology, French Revolutionary Wars
Objectives	Compare two interpretations from the chapter about the role of Enlightenment ideology versus pragmatic responses in driving revolutionary actions and give one piece of evidence the chapter uses for each view.; Describe how wartime mobilization changed French military scale and political dynamics between 1792 and 1795, citing the chapter's figures.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge (5 min), Introduce new material (10 min), Guided debate prep in groups (10 min), Structured debate and small-group discussion (6 min), Role play (7 min), Check and consolidate (2 min)
Why this order	This period builds on the Republic Proclaimed and the Reign of Terror material (including Assignats and Terror repression) by showing how war, economic strain and political violence shaped the weak Directory. It prepares students to assess the Thermidorian reaction, colonial slavery debates, media and womens roles, and the Directory's collapse into 18 Brumaire.

Period 5: Revolutionary Aftershocks: Colonies, Economy, Symbols

Concepts	Thermidorian reaction, Slavery and the colonies, Media and revolutionary symbolism, Role of women during the Revolution, Economic policies and consequences
Objectives	Explain why the Storming of the Bastille became a potent symbol of the Ancien Régime despite the fortress holding few prisoners, citing the chapter's description.; Describe the immediate legal changes enacted by the August Decrees concerning feudal dues and church tithes and one practical difficulty the text reports in implementing them.; Explain how confiscation of church property and the issue of assignats related to the fiscal situation and inflation as described in the chapter.; Explain the chapter's account of how metropolitan debates over rights affected the

	colonies, especially Saint-Domingue, and what policy responses from 1791 to 1793 followed.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge (6 min), Introduce new material (10 min), Guided role play and debate (12 min), Check for understanding (6 min), Consolidate and reflect (6 min)
Why this order	This period builds on the Directory period's discussion of political instability, contested ideology, and wartime pressures by tracing how those debates shaped colonial policy, economic measures, and symbolic politics; it prepares students to evaluate the Revolution's long-term consequences and historiography in the following readings on impact and scholarly interpretations.

Period 6: Long-Term Impacts and Historiography

Concepts	Long-term impact of the Revolution, Encyclopaedia Britannica article on the French Revolution (citation), Monograph: Guillotine (Opie, 1997), Academic paper: The Consequences of Radical Reform (Acemoglu et al., 2011), Extensive bibliography on the French Revolution
Objectives	Recall the conventional start and end events and dates of the French Revolution as stated in the text.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge (5 min), Introduce new material (8 min), Group discussion / evidence weighing (12 min), Role play / historiography jigsaw (8 min), Check for understanding (4 min), Consolidate and next steps (3 min)
Why this order	This period builds on the preceding study of Thermidorian reaction, colonial slavery, revolutionary symbols, women's roles, and economic policy by moving from immediate outcomes to long-term consequences and how historians explain them; as the closing lesson it synthesises those threads and points students to the cited sources (Britannica, Opie, Acemoglu et al.) and the extensive bibliography for independent follow-up.

Concepts Taught

Concept	Importance	Summary
Causes of the Revolution (multiple factors)	core	The Revolution resulted from a combination of social, economic, financial and political crises, resistance to reform, and indecisive royal policy.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Estates General of 1789 and Third Estate actions	core	The Estates-General convened in May 1789; the Third Estate broke away, verified its members, and declared itself the National Assembly.
Tennis Court Oath	supporting	After the Estates-General meeting place was closed, deputies took an oath not to disperse until a constitution had been agreed.
Storming of the Bastille (14 July 1789)	core	The Bastille was attacked on 14 July 1789; though it held few prisoners, its fall became a potent symbol of the Ancien R9gime and is commemorated as Bastille Day.
August Decrees and abolition of feudalism	core	The Assembly published the August Decrees which abolished feudalism, cancelled feudal dues and church tithes, and established equality before the law.
Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen	supporting	A statement of principles produced during the Revolution and published on 26 August 1789 as part of drafting a constitution.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Constitutional monarchy phase (July 1789 e2 2 September 1792)	core	A phase in which France had a constitutional monarchy, including creation of a constitution, restrictions such as 'active' and 'passive' citizens, and political tensions culminating in the king's loss of authority.
Louis XVI's flight to Varennes (June 1791)	supporting	The royal family's attempted escape in June 1791 ended with their arrest at Varennes and increased suspicion of the king, undermining his authority.
Proclamation of the French First Republic (1792)	core	On 22 September 1792 the Convention replaced the monarchy with the French First Republic and introduced a new calendar starting Year One (1792).
Reign of Terror (Sept 1793 e2 2 July 1794)	core	A period of political repression where the Law of Suspects and emergency measures led to mass arrests and executions conducted by the Revolutionary government.
Assignats (paper currency backed by confiscated church property)	supporting	The Assembly confiscated church property and used its value to back a new paper currency called assignats.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Repression during the Terror	core	Describes the large-scale violence and executions during the Terror, including drownings at Nantes, executions of Hébertists and Danton, the Law of 22 Prairial, and the execution of Robespierre.
Thermidorian reaction	supporting	The political reaction after Robespierre's fall involving revenge killings in southern France, executions of Commune leaders, repeal of the Law of 22 Prairial, closure of the Jacobin Club, and negotiated peace treaties.
French Directory (1795–1799) — structure and problems	core	Describes the Directory's bicameral legislative context, weak executive (five directors), political unrest, economic weakness, reliance on the army, chronic violence and corruption, and its eventual overthrow in the coup of 18 Brumaire.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Contested role of ideology	core	Presents differing historical views on whether Enlightenment ideology (radical Enlightenment) or pragmatic responses to immediate problems primarily drove the Revolution; notes variety of factions and interpretations of the Declaration of the Rights of Man.
French Revolutionary Wars	core	A series of conflicts from 1792 to 1815 initiated by the Revolution that involved major European powers and transformed warfare by mobilising nations and national resources; early victories led to territorial gains and satellite republics.
Slavery and the colonies	core	Details the centrality of Caribbean colonies (especially Saint-Domingue), the formation of abolitionist and pro-slavery groups, uprisings in Saint-Domingue, the commissioners' actions, and the Convention's abolition of slavery in 1794 with varying enforcement and restrictions on freed people.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Media and revolutionary symbolism	supporting	Explains the central role of newspapers and pamphlets in the Revolution, the proliferation of publications, and the deliberate creation and redefinition of symbols (e.g., tricolour, liberty cap) to replace old-regime religious and monarchical symbols.
Role of women during the Revolution	supporting	Covers women's activism including authors and agitators, their participation in demonstrations and clubs, the eventual denial of political rights in 1791 and 1793 constitutions, and the banning of women's clubs in October 1793.
Economic policies and consequences	core	Lists economic changes: abolition of tithes, nationalisation of church lands and use as assignats, end of guilds and tax farming, severe inflation and economic disruption, and later monetary stabilization with the Franc germinal in 1803.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Long-term impact of the Revolution	core	The Revolution ended feudalism in France, influenced modern nationalism and the nation-state concept, reshaped French society (land redistribution, decline of aristocratic power), and exported institutions and ideas across Europe and beyond.
Encyclopaedia Britannica article on the French Revolution (citation)	supporting	The document cites a Britannica overview article titled 'French Revolution History, Summary, Timeline, Causes, & Facts' as a reference.
Monograph: Guillotine (Opie, 1997)	supporting	The bibliography includes a monograph entry: Opie, Robert Frederick (1997). Guillotine. History Press.
Academic paper: The Consequences of Radical Reform (Acemoglu et al., 2011)	supporting	The document cites an academic working paper / journal article by Acemoglu, Cantoni, Johnson, and Robinson (2011) titled 'The Consequences of Radical Reform: The French Revolution'.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Extensive bibliography on the French Revolution	core	This section of the document contains an extensive bibliography and further reading list with many scholarly works (books, articles, theses) on various aspects of the French Revolution.